

Email & business writing

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

Email is the default professional communication channel — for applying to jobs, following up after interviews, communicating with recruiters, and, once placed, coordinating with managers and teams. Unlike casual chat, professional email has established conventions around structure, tone, and length that get judged (often unconsciously) as a proxy for how organized and professional the sender is. A vague subject line, a missing greeting, or a three-paragraph email that could have been three sentences all cost credibility before the content is even read. This sub-module covers the anatomy of a professional email, how to write for busy recipients who skim rather than read, and gives literal templates for the emails students will actually need to send during placements: a follow-up after an interview, a request to a professor or recruiter, and an escalation when something has gone wrong.

1. Anatomy of a Professional Email

Every professional email has five parts that each do a specific job: a specific subject line (so the recipient knows what it's about before opening), a greeting matched to formality level, an opening line stating the purpose immediately, a body with any necessary detail, and a sign-off with your full name and relevant context (e.g., roll number, applied role). Skipping or weakening any one of these makes the email harder to act on. The subject line is disproportionately important because it is the only part visible in an inbox list — 'Question' or 'Hi' forces the recipient to open the email just to find out what it's about, while 'Follow-up: Software Engineer Interview – 15 Sept' tells them immediately.

- Weak subject: 'Regarding the interview' — Strong subject: 'Follow-up on Backend Developer Interview – Priya Sharma'
- Weak opening: 'Hope you are doing well. I wanted to reach out because...' (buries the ask) — Strong opening: 'I'm writing to follow up on my interview for the Backend Developer role on 15 September.'

2. BLUF: Bottom Line Up Front

Professional readers, especially recruiters and managers handling high email volume, skim rather than read line by line. The BLUF principle — state the main point or request in the first sentence, then provide supporting detail — respects this reality. An email that opens with three sentences of context before finally arriving at the actual ask ('I was wondering if it might be possible to...') risks the reader losing patience or missing the ask altogether. Leading with the point doesn't mean being curt or rude; it means structuring for how the email will actually be read, with pleasantries and detail supporting the main line rather than delaying it.

- Instead of: 'I hope this email finds you well. I have been following up on various opportunities and was hoping to know if there might be any update regarding my application...' — write: 'I'm writing to ask if there's an update on my application for the Data Analyst role (applied 3 Sept). Happy to provide any additional information needed.'

3. Matching Tone and Formality to the Recipient

Tone should shift based on relationship and context, but professional email defaults to a register that is warm without being casual — avoiding both stiff over-formality ('Respected Sir/Madam, I beg to state that...') and excessive casualness ('Hey! quick q lol!'). Addressing someone by name ('Dear Mr. Verma' or 'Hi Rohan' depending on established rapport) is almost always better than generic salutations like 'To whomsoever it may concern' when a name is known. Sign-offs should match: 'Best regards' or 'Thank you' work broadly; 'Regards' is slightly more clipped and fine for brief follow-ups; overly casual sign-offs ('Cheers', 'Thanks a ton!') should be reserved for contexts where that relationship is already established.

4. Templates for Placement-Specific Emails

Three email types come up constantly during placements: the cold outreach/application email, the post-interview follow-up, and the polite escalation when a response is overdue. Each has a slightly different structure but follows the same core principles — clear subject, immediate purpose, concise body, professional close. Having a mental template for each removes the anxiety of drafting from scratch under time pressure.

- Post-interview follow-up: Subject: 'Thank You – Backend Developer Interview, 15 Sept'. Body: 'Dear Mr. Iyer, Thank you for taking the time to speak with me yesterday about the Backend Developer role. I enjoyed learning more about the team's work on the payments system, and our discussion reinforced my interest in the position. Please let me know if you need any further information from my side. Best regards, Priya Sharma'

- Polite escalation after no response: Subject: 'Following Up: Application Status – Data Analyst Role'. Body: 'Hi Ms. Rao, I wanted to follow up on my application submitted on 3 September, as I haven't heard back yet. I understand things can get busy — could you share any update on the timeline when convenient? Thank you, Rohan Mehta'

5. Formatting for Scannability

Even a short email benefits from formatting that makes it easy to scan: short paragraphs (2-4 sentences), a blank line between paragraphs, and bullet points when listing more than two items rather than burying them in a sentence. An email asking a recipient to confirm three separate details should list those three details as bullets, not weave them into one dense paragraph the reader has to parse carefully. Bold text should be used sparingly, if at all, in professional email — over-formatting can look unprofessional or aggressive; plain, well-structured text is usually sufficient.

6. Proofreading and Common Formatting Mistakes

A single typo in a job application email may be forgiven; a wrong name (addressing 'Dear Mr. Sharma' when the recipient is 'Ms. Sharma' or entirely the wrong person because a template wasn't updated) is much harder to recover from. Before sending, checking the recipient's name and title, the subject line, any attached file's name (a resume file literally named 'Resume_Final_v3_USE THIS ONE.pdf' looks careless), and the 'Reply All' vs 'Reply' choice are all worth a deliberate 10-second check. Reading the email aloud once before sending catches awkward phrasing that silent reading misses.

- Rename resume attachments professionally: 'Priya_Sharma_Resume.pdf', not 'resume final(2) copy.pdf'.
- Double-check 'Reply All' — accidentally CC'ing an entire recruitment list with a personal follow-up is a common, avoidable mistake.

7. Email Etiquette Pitfalls in Group and Recruiter Threads

Group email threads (e.g., a placement coordinator looping in multiple recruiters or students) have their own etiquette: trimming unnecessary quoted history when replying, using 'Reply' instead of 'Reply All' unless the whole group genuinely needs your message, and avoiding one-word replies ('Ok', 'Thanks') that add another notification for a large group without adding information. When multiple people are CC'd, addressing the specific person you're responding to by name at the start of the reply avoids ambiguity about who the message is for.

Common Pitfalls

- Vague subject lines like 'Hi' or 'Question' that give the recipient no idea what the email is about.
- Burying the actual request three sentences deep instead of leading with it (violating BLUF).
- Using an overly stiff, outdated register ('Respected Sir, I beg to state') that reads as unnatural rather than formal.
- Sending a follow-up or application email with the wrong recipient name because a template wasn't updated.
- Attaching a resume file with an unprofessional or messy filename.
- Hitting 'Reply All' on a large thread with a message meant for one person.
- Writing dense, unformatted paragraphs when a short bulleted list would be far easier to act on.

Key Takeaways

- A specific subject line saves the reader time and makes your email more likely to be opened promptly.
- Lead with the point (BLUF) — supporting detail comes after, not before, the main ask.
- Match tone to context: warm but professional beats both stiff formality and excessive casualness.

- Keep placement email templates (follow-up, escalation, outreach) ready mentally so you're not drafting from scratch under pressure.
- Always proofread the recipient's name, the subject line, and attachment filenames before sending.
- Format for scanning — short paragraphs and bullets — because most professional email is skimmed, not read word for word.

Learn More

Indeed — How to Write a Professional Email (With Examples)

<https://www.indeed.com/career-advice/career-development/how-to-write-a-professional-email>

Harvard Business Review — How to Write Email With Military Precision

<https://hbr.org/2016/11/how-to-write-email-with-military-precision>

Grammarly Blog — Business Email Etiquette

<https://www.grammarly.com/blog/emailing/business-email-etiquette/>